

Remember that detection should be only one of a range of strategies to reduce plagiarism. Reliance on detection via the Internet in completed works will only locate a proportion of plagiarised work; it won't identify works that are not in the digital domain, nor will it identify the efforts of the more sophisticated "cheaters".

Furthermore the threat of being caught is unlikely to be truly effective unless combined with the development of an understanding of what plagiarism is and why it should be avoided, as well as research and referencing skills as described on the Avoiding Plagiarism page.

More useful information on creating assessment tasks that discourage plagiarism may be found in the Planning research assignments pages.

Suggestions for detection of plagiarism

- Develop some idea of the writing skills of the students; a brief handwritten piece on a topic with which they are familiar, early in a course, will give you a good starting point for noticing:
 - uncharacteristically well written passages, or fragments within a work.
 - unusual or conspicuous grammatical errors which may be indicative of a student deliberately "dumbing down" a plagiarised work in an attempt to avoid detection.
- Use an Internet search engine to check if an Internet based material has been plagiarised in an assignment. This process is straight forward, but has been proven effective on many occasions at St. Michael's. If essays are handed in in electronic format it will further simplify the process by saving additional typing.
 1. Identify a distinctive fragment of text; four words is often sufficient to identify a unique combination.
 2. Copy this text into a search engine such as [Google](#) and add quotation marks at each end of the text to ensure the exact wording is searched, e.g. "after the late failure of radical hopes". (If you have an electronic version of the essay, copy the text, minimise word, open Internet Explorer, go to [Google](#) and paste the text).
 3. Internet search results can then be investigated to identify sources of copied material. (Remember that even the best search engines only search about 25% of the Internet, so a thorough search should include more than one search engine, possibly by utilising a meta-search engine such as [Dogpile](#).)